4 Email, keys and AI

QUICK

16. Google AI Studio and Gemini: research, coding help, and knowing your computer

Quick version

No time to read it all? This is the short version. The full guide is below.

- Google AI Studio (https://aistudio.google.com) is Google's free web page for Gemini: web search with sources, coding help, and a free API key.
- To search the web, switch on **Grounding with Google Search** under Tools. Open the sources it lists: trust the source, not the summary.
- A free key for the AI boxes: **Get API key**, **Create API key**, then on the garden computer menu `8`, `4`, `1` (Gemini), `1` again (Paste a new key) and paste it. It is hidden and saved in `.env`.
- Free keys have daily limits. When they are reached, the AI boxes wait and try again later. That is normal.
- To learn about your computer: `bash lab/10-collect-for-gemini.sh` collects facts with passwords and keys removed.
- Paying is your choice and never needed. If you ever add billing, set a budget alert first.
- Never paste `.env`, a password, an API key or a backup into any AI chat. If a key leaks, make a new one and delete the old one.